

Athos immediately began and offered in due form the hand of the Princess Henrietta Stuart to the young prince, the king's brother. The conference lasted an hour; after which the doors of the chamber were thrown open to the courtiers, who resumed their places as if nothing had been kept from them in the occupations of that evening. Athos then found himself again with Raoul, and the father and son were able to clasp each other's hands.

Chapter XLII

In Which Mazarin Becomes Prodigal



HILST Mazarin was endeavouring to recover from the serious alarm he had just experienced, Athos and Raoul were exchanging a few words in a corner of the apartment. 'Well, here you are at Paris, then, Raoul?' said the comte.

'Yes, monsieur, since the return of M. le Prince.'

'I cannot converse freely with you here, because we are observed; but I shall return home presently, and shall expect you as soon as your duty permits.'

Raoul bowed, and, at that moment, M. le Prince came up to them. The prince had that clear and keen look which distinguishes birds of prey of the noble species; his physiognomy itself presented several distinct traits of this resemblance. It is known that in the Prince de Condé, the aquiline nose rose out sharply and incisively from a brow slightly retreating, rather low than high, and according to the railers of the court,—a pitiless race without mercy even for genius,—constituted rather an eagle's beak than a human nose, in the heir of the illustrious princes of the house of Condé. This penetrating look, this imperious expression of the whole countenance, generally disturbed those to whom the prince spoke, more than either majesty or regular beauty could have done in the conqueror of Rocroi. Besides this, the fire mounted so suddenly to his projecting eyes, that with the prince every sort of animation resembled passion. Now, on account of his rank, everybody at the court respected M. le Prince, and many even, seeing only the man, carried their respect as far as terror.

Louis de Condé then advanced towards the Comte de la Fère and Raoul, with the marked intention of being saluted by the one, and of speaking with the other. No man bowed with more reserved grace than the Comte de la Fère. He disdained to put into a salutation all the shades which a courtier ordinarily borrows from the same colour—the desire to please. Athos knew his own personal value, and bowed to the prince like a man, correcting by something sympathetic and undefinable that which might have appeared offensive to the pride of the highest rank in the inflexibility of his attitude. The prince was about to speak to Raoul. Athos forestalled him. 'If M. le Vicomte de Bragelonne,' said he, 'were not one of the humble servants of your royal highness, I would beg him to pronounce my name before you—mon prince.' 'I have the honour to address Monsieur le Comte de la Fère,' said Condé, instantly.

'My protector,' added Raoul, blushing.

'One of the most honourable men in the kingdom,' continued the prince; 'one of the first gentlemen of France, and of whom I have heard so much that I have frequently desired to number him among my friends.'

'An honour of which I should be unworthy,' replied Athos, 'but for the respect and admiration I entertain for your royal highness.'

'Monsieur de Bragelonne,' said the prince, 'is a good officer, and it is plainly seen that he has been to a good school. Ah, monsieur le comte, in your time, generals had soldiers!'

'That is true, my lord, but nowadays soldiers have generals.'

This compliment, which savoured so little of flattery, gave a thrill of joy to the man whom already Europe considered a hero; and who might be thought to be satiated with praise.

'I regret very much,' continued the prince, 'that you should have retired from the service, monsieur le comte; for it is more than probable that the king will soon have a war with Holland or England, and opportunities for distinguishing himself would not be wanting for a man who, like you, knows Great Britain as well as you do France.'

'I believe I may say, monseigneur, that I have acted wisely in retiring from the service,' said Athos, smiling. 'France and Great Britain will henceforward live like two sisters, if I can trust my presentiments.'

'Your presentiments?'

'The name of that gentleman?'

'It was your humble servant,' said Athos, simply and bowing.

A murmur of admiration made the heart of Athos swell with pleasure. He had reason to be proud, at least. Mazarin, himself, had raised his arms towards heaven.

'Monsieur,' said the king, 'I shall seek and find means to reward you.' Athos made a movement. 'Oh, not for your honesty, to be paid for that would humiliate you; but I owe you a reward for having participated in the restoration of my brother, King Charles II.'

'Certainly,' said Mazarin.

'It is the triumph of a good cause which fills the whole house of France with joy,' said Anne of Austria.

'I continue,' said Louis XIV. 'Is it also true that a single man penetrated to Monk, in his camp, and carried him off?'

'That man had ten auxiliaries, taken from a very inferior rank.'

'And nothing more but them?'

'Nothing more.'

'And he is named?'

'Monsieur d'Aragnan, formerly lieutenant of the musketeers of your majesty,' Anne of Austria coloured; Mazarin became yellow with shame; Louis XIV was deeply thoughtful, and a drop of moisture fell from his pale brow. 'What men!' murmured he. And, involuntarily, he darted a glance at the minister which would have terrified him, if Mazarin, at the moment, had not concealed his head under his pillow.

'Monsieur,' said the young Duc d'Anjou, placing his hand, delicate and white as that of a woman, upon the arm of Athos, 'tell that brave man, I beg you, that Monsieur, brother of the king, will to-morrow drink his health before five hundred of the best gentlemen of France.' And, on finishing those words, the young man, perceiving that his enthusiasm had deranged one of his ruffles, set to work to put it to rights with the greatest care imaginable.

'Let us resume business, sire,' interrupted Mazarin, who never was enthusiastic, and who wore no ruffles.

'Yes, monsieur,' replied Louis XIV 'Pursue your communication, monsieur le comte,' added he, turning towards Athos.

‘Oh! oh! but he is a scoundrel, that Frenchman,’ said Mazarin; ‘and the idea is not so ingenious as to prevent its author being tied up by the neck at the Place de Grève, by decree of the parliament.’

‘Your eminence is mistaken,’ replied Athos, dryly; ‘I did not say that the Frenchman in question had resolved to assassinate M. Monk, but only to suppress him. The words of the French language have a value which the gentlemen of France know perfectly. Besides, this is an affair of war; and when men serve kings against their enemies they are not to be condemned by a parliament—God is their judge. This French gentleman, then, formed the idea of gaining possession of the person of Monk, and he executed his plan.’

The king became animated at the recital of great actions. The king’s younger brother struck the table with his hand, exclaiming, ‘Ah! that is fine!’

‘He carried off Monk?’ said the king. ‘Why, Monk was in his camp.’

‘And the gentleman was alone, sire.’

‘That is marvellous!’ said Philip.

‘Marvelous, indeed!’ cried the king.

‘Good! There are the two little lions unchained,’ murmured the cardinal. And with an air of spite, which he did not dissemble: ‘I am unacquainted with these details, will you guarantee their authenticity, monsieur?’

‘All the more easily, my lord cardinal, from having seen the events.’

‘You have?’

‘Yes, monseigneur.’

The king had involuntarily drawn close to the count, the Duc d’Anjou had turned sharply round, and pressed Athos on the other side.

‘What next? monsieur, what next?’ cried they both at the same time.

‘Sire, M. Monk, being taken by the Frenchman, was brought to King Charles II, at the Hague. The king gave back his freedom to Monk, and the grateful general, in return, gave Charles II the throne of Great Britain, for which so many valiant men had fought in vain.’

Philip clapped his hands with enthusiasm, Louis XIV, more reflective, turned towards the Comte de la Fère.

‘Is this true,’ said he, ‘in all its details?’

‘Absolutely true, sire.’

‘That one of my gentlemen knew the secret of the million, and kept it?’
‘Yes, sire.’

‘Stop, monseigneur, listen to what is being said yonder, at the table of my lord the cardinal.’

‘Where they are playing?’

‘Yes, my lord.’

The cardinal had just raised himself on one elbow, and made a sign to the king’s brother, who went to him.

‘My lord,’ said the cardinal, ‘pick up, if you please, all those gold crowns.’ And he pointed to the enormous pile of yellow and glittering pieces which the Comte de Guiche had raised by degrees before him by a surprising run of luck at play.

‘For me?’ cried the Duc d’Anjou.

‘Those fifty thousand crowns; yes, monseigneur, they are yours.’

‘Do you give them to me?’

‘I have been playing on your account, monseigneur,’ replied the cardinal, getting weaker and weaker, as if this effort of giving money had exhausted all his physical and moral faculties.

‘Oh, good heavens!’ exclaimed Philip, wild with joy, ‘what a fortunate day!’ And he himself, making a rake of his fingers, drew a part of the sum into his pockets, which he filled, and still full a third remained on the table.

‘Chevalier,’ said Philip to his favourite, the Chevalier de Lorraine, ‘come hither, chevalier.’ The favourite quickly obeyed. ‘Pocket the rest,’ said the young prince.

This singular scene was considered by the persons present only as a touching kind of family fête. The cardinal assumed the airs of a father with the sons of France, and the two princes had grown up under his wing. No one then imputed to pride, or even impertinence, as would be done nowadays, this liberality on the part of the first minister. The courtiers were satisfied with envying the prince.—The king turned away his head.

‘I never had so much money before,’ said the young prince, joyously, as he crossed the chamber with his favourite to go to his carriage. ‘No, never! What a weight these crowns are!’

‘But why has monsieur le cardinal given away all this money at once?’ asked M. le Prince of the Comte de la Fère. ‘He must be very ill, the dear cardinal!’
‘Yes, my lord, very ill, without doubt; he looks very ill, as your royal highness may perceive.’

‘But surely he will die of it. A hundred and fifty thousand livres! Oh, it is incredible! But, come, tell me a reason for it?’

‘Patience, monseigneur, I beg of you. Here comes M. le Duc d’Anjou, talking with the Chevalier de Lorraine; I should not be surprised if they spared us the trouble of being indiscreet. Listen to them.’

In fact the chevalier said to the prince in a low voice, ‘My lord, it is not natural for M. Mazarin to give you so much money. Take care! you will let some of the pieces fall, my lord. What design has the cardinal upon you to make him so generous?’

‘As I said,’ whispered Athos in the prince’s ear; ‘that, perhaps, is the best reply to your question.’

‘Tell me, my lord,’ repeated the chevalier impatiently, as he was calculating, by weighing them in his pocket, the quota of the sum which had fallen to his share by rebound.

‘My dear chevalier, a wedding present.’

‘How a wedding present?’

‘Eh! yes, I am going to be married,’ replied the Duc d’Anjou, without perceiving, at the moment, he was passing the prince and Athos, who both bowed respectfully.

The chevalier darted at the young duke a glance so strange, and so malicious, that the Comte de la Fère quite started on beholding it.

‘You! you to be married!’ repeated he; ‘oh! that’s impossible. You would not commit such a folly!’

‘Bah! I don’t do it myself; I am made to do it,’ replied the Duc d’Anjou.

‘But come, quick! let us get rid of our money.’ Thereupon he disappeared with his companion, laughing and talking, whilst all heads were bowed on his passage.

‘Then,’ whispered the prince to Athos, ‘that is the secret.’

‘It was not I who told you so, my lord.’

‘He is to marry the sister of Charles II?’

‘I believe so.’

The prince reflected for a moment, and his eye shot forth one of its not infrequent flashes. ‘Humph!’ said he slowly, as if speaking to himself; ‘our swords are once more to be hung on the wall—for a long time!’ and he sighed.

‘These are exactly the details I asked for,’ said the king. ‘Who and what are the two men of whom you speak?’

‘Two Frenchmen, sire.’

‘Indeed! I am glad of that.’

‘And the two ideas,’ said Mazarin;—‘I am more curious about ideas than about men, for my part.’

‘Yes,’ murmured the king.

‘The second idea, the devoted, reasonable idea—the least important, sir—was to go and dig up a million in gold, buried by King Charles I at Newcastle, and to purchase with that gold the adherence of Monk.’

‘Oh, oh!’ said Mazarin, reanimated by the word million. ‘But Newcastle was at the time occupied by Monk.’

‘Yes, monsieur le cardinal, and that is why I venture to call the idea courageous as well as devoted. It was necessary, if Monk refused the offers of the negotiator, to reinstate King Charles II in possession of this million, which was to be torn, as it were, from the loyalty and not the loyalism of General Monk. This was effected in spite of many difficulties: the general proved to be loyal, and allowed the money to be taken away.’

‘It seems to me,’ said the timid, thoughtful king, ‘that Charles II could not have known of this million whilst he was in Paris.’

‘It seems to me,’ rejoined the cardinal, maliciously, ‘that his majesty the king of Great Britain knew perfectly well of this million, but that he preferred having two millions to having one.’

‘Sire,’ said Athos, firmly, ‘the king of England, whilst in France, was so poor that he had not even money to take the post; so destitute of hope that he frequently thought of dying. He was so entirely ignorant of the existence of the million at Newcastle, that but for a gentleman—one of your majesty’s subjects—the moral depository of the million, who revealed the secret to King Charles II, that prince would still be vegetating in the most cruel forgetfulness.’

‘Let us pass on to the strange, bold and ingenious idea,’ interrupted Mazarin, whose sagacity foresaw a check. ‘What was that idea?’

‘This—M. Monk formed the only obstacle to the re-establishment of the fallen king. A Frenchman imagined the idea of suppressing this obstacle.’

at the same time the mysteries which the young had not seen, and which the old had believed to be forever effaced.

‘Speak, monsieur,’ said Louis XIV, the first to escape from troubles, suspicions, and remembrances.

‘Yes, speak,’ added Mazarin, to whom the little malicious thrust directed against Anne of Austria had restored energy and gayer.

‘Sire,’ said the comte, ‘a sort of miracle has changed the whole destiny of Charles II. That which men, till that time, had been unable to do, God resolved to accomplish.’

Mazarin coughed while tossing about in his bed.

‘King Charles II,’ continued Athos, ‘left the Hague neither as a fugitive nor a conqueror, but as an absolute king, who, after a distant voyage from his kingdom, returns amidst universal benedictions.’

‘A great miracle, indeed,’ said Mazarin; ‘for, if the news was true, King Charles II, who has just returned amidst benedictions, went away amidst musket-shots.’

The king remained impassible. Philip, younger and more frivolous, could not repress a smile, which flattered Mazarin as an applause of his pleasantries.

‘It is plain,’ said the king, ‘there is a miracle; but God, who does so much for kings, monsieur le comte, nevertheless employs the hand of man to bring about the triumph of His designs. To what men does Charles II principally owe his re-establishment?’

‘Why,’ interrupted Mazarin, without any regard for the king’s pride—‘does not your majesty know that it is to M. Monk?’

‘I ought to know it,’ replied Louis XIV, resolutely; ‘and yet I ask my lord ambassador, the causes of the change in this General Monk?’

‘And your majesty touches precisely the question,’ replied Athos; ‘for without the miracle of which I have had the honour to speak, General Monk would probably have remained an implacable enemy of Charles II. God willed that a strange, bold, and ingenious idea should enter into the mind of a certain man, whilst a devoted and courageous idea took possession of the mind of another man. The combinations of these two ideas brought about such a change in the position of M. Monk, that, from an inveterate enemy, he became a friend to the deposed king.’

All that sigh contained of ambition silently stifled, of extinguished illusions and disappointed hopes, Athos alone divined, for he alone heard that sigh. Immediately after, the prince took leave and the king left the apartment. Athos, by a sign made to Bragelonne, renewed the desire he had expressed at the beginning of the scene. By degrees the chamber was deserted, and Mazarin was left alone, a prey to suffering which he could no longer dissemble. ‘Bernouin! Bernouin!’ cried he in a broken voice.

‘What does monseigneur want?’

‘Guenaud—let Guenaud be sent for,’ said his eminence. ‘I think I’m dying,’ Bernouin, in great terror, rushed into the cabinet to give the order, and the piqueur, who hastened to fetch the physician, passed the king’s carriage in the Rue Saint Honore.

Chapter XII

The Recital



HE maliciousness of the cardinal did not leave much for the ambassador to say; nevertheless, the word 'restoration' had struck the king, who, addressing the comte, upon whom his eyes had been fixed since his entrance,— 'Monsieur,' said he, 'will you have the kindness to give us some details concerning the affairs of England. You come from that country, you are a Frenchman, and the orders which I see glittering upon your person announce you to be a man of merit as well as a man of quality.'

'Monsieur,' said the cardinal, turning towards the queen-mother, 'is an ancient servant of your majesty's, Monsieur le Comte de la Pèrè.'

Anne of Austria was as oblivious as a queen whose life had been mingled with fine and stormy days. She looked at Mazarin, whose evil smile promised her something disagreeable; then she solicited from Athos, by another look, an explanation.

'Monsieur,' continued the cardinal, 'was a Treville musketeer, in the service of the late king. Monsieur is well acquainted with England, whither he has made several voyages at various periods; he is a subject of the highest merit.'

These words made allusion to all the memories which Anne of Austria trembled to evoke. England, that was her hatred of Richelieu and her love for Buckingham; a Treville musketeer, that was the whole Odyssey of the triumphs which had made the heart of the young woman throb, and of the dangers which had been so near overturning the throne of the young queen. These words had much power, for they rendered mute and attentive all the royal personages, who, with very various sentiments, set about recomposing

Chapter XLIII

Guenaud



HE cardinal's order was pressing; Guenaud quickly obeyed it. He found his patient stretched on his bed, his legs swelled, his face livid, and his stomach collapsed. Mazarin had a severe attack of gout. He suffered tortures with the impatience of a man who has not been accustomed to resistances. On seeing Guenaud: 'Ah! said he; now I am saved!'

Guenaud was a very learned and circumspect man, who stood in no need of the critiques of Boileau to obtain a reputation. When facing a disease, if it were personified in a king, he treated the patient as a Turk treats a Moor. He did not, therefore, reply to Mazarin as the minister expected: 'Here is the doctor; good-bye disease!' On the contrary, on examining his patient, with a very serious air:

'Oh! oh!' said he.

'Eh! what! Guenaud! How you look at me!'

'I look as I should on seeing your complaint, my lord; it is a very dangerous one.'

'The gout—oh! yes, the gout.'

'With complications, my lord.'

Mazarin raised himself upon his elbow, and, questioning by look and gesture: 'What do you mean by that? Am I worse than I believe myself to be?'

'My lord,' said Guenaud, seating himself beside the bed; 'your eminence has worked very hard during your life; your eminence has suffered much.'

'But I am not old, I fancy. The late M. de Richelieu was but seventeen months younger than I am when he died, and died of a mortal disease. I am young, Guenaud: remember, I am scarcely fifty-two.'

'Oh! my lord, you are much more than that. How long did the Fronde last?'

'For what purpose do you put such a question to me?'

'For a medical calculation, monseigneur.'

'Well, some ten years—off and on.'

'Very well; be kind enough to reckon every year of the Fronde as three years—that makes thirty; now twenty and fifty-two makes seventy-two years. You are seventy-two, my lord; and that is a great age.'

Whilst saying this, he felt the pulse of his patient. This pulse was full of such fatal indications, that the physician continued, notwithstanding the interruptions of the patient: 'Put down the years of the Fronde at four each, and you have lived eighty-two years.'

'Are you speaking seriously, Guenaud?'

'Alas! yes, monseigneur.'

'You take a roundabout way, then, to inform me that I am very ill?'

'Ma foi! yes, my lord, and with a man of the mind and courage of your eminence, it ought not to be necessary to do so.'

The cardinal breathed with such difficulty that he inspired pity even in a pitiless physician. 'There are diseases and diseases,' resumed Mazarin. 'From some of them people escape.'

'That is true, my lord.'

'Is it not?' cried Mazarin, almost joyously; 'for, in short, what else would be the use of power, of strength of will? What would the use of genius be—your genius, Guenaud? What would be the use of science and art, if the patient, who disposes of all that, cannot be saved from peril?'

Guenaud was about to open his mouth, but Mazarin continued:

'Remember,' said he, 'I am the most confiding of your patients; remember I obey you blindly, and that consequently—'

'I know all that,' said Guenaud.

'I shall be cured, then?'

'Monseigneur, there is neither strength of will, nor power, nor genius, nor science that can resist a disease which God doubtless sends, or which He cast upon the earth at the creation, with full power to destroy and kill mankind. When the disease is mortal, and nothing can—'

'Is—my—disease—mortal?' asked Mazarin.

'A friend!' murmured the Comte de la Fère, at witnessing with stupor this monstrous alliance of words;—'friends! when the parties are Condé and Mazarin!'

Mazarin seemed to divine the thoughts of the Frondeur, for he smiled upon him with triumph, and immediately,—'Sire,' said he to the king, 'I have the honour of presenting to your majesty, Monsieur le Comte de la Fère, ambassador from his Britannic majesty. An affair of state, gentlemen,' added he, waving his hand to all who filled the chamber, and who, the Prince de Condé at their head, all disappeared at the simple gesture. Raoul, after a last look cast at the comte, followed M. de Condé. Philip of Anjou and the queen appeared to be consulting about departing.

'A family affair,' said Mazarin, suddenly, detaining them in their seats. 'This gentleman is the bearer of a letter in which King Charles II, completely restored to his throne, demands an alliance between Monsieur, the brother of the king, and Mademoiselle Henrietta, grand-daughter of Henry IV. Will you remit your letter of credit to the king, monsieur le comte?'

Athos remained for a minute stupefied. How could the minister possibly know the contents of the letter, which had never been out of his keeping for a single instant? Nevertheless, always master of himself, he held out the dispatch to the young king, Louis XIV, who took it with a blush. A solemn silence reigned in the cardinal's chamber. It was only troubled by the dull sound of the gold, which Mazarin, with his yellow, dry hand, piled up in a casket, whilst the king was reading.

‘Be it so. I say that this negotiation must pass through my hands. Let us lose no precious time, then. Tell me the conditions.’

‘I have had the honour of assuring your eminence that only the letter of his majesty King Charles II contains the revelation of his wishes.’

‘Pooh! you are ridiculous with your obstinacy, Monsieur Athos. It is plain you have kept company with the Puritans yonder. As to your secret, I know it better than you do; and you have done wrongly, perhaps, in not having shown some respect for a very old and suffering man, who has laboured much during his life, and kept the field for his ideas as bravely as you have for yours. You will not communicate your letter to me? You will say nothing to me? Very well! Come with me into my chamber; you shall speak to the king—and before the king—Now, then, one last word: who gave you the Fleece? I remember you passed for having the Garter; but as to the Fleece, I do not know—’

‘Recently, my lord, Spain, on the occasion of the marriage of his majesty Louis XIV, sent King Charles II a brevet of the Fleece in blank; Charles II immediately transmitted it to me, filling up the blank with my name.’

Mazarin arose, and leaning on the arm of Bernouin, he returned to his ruelle at the moment the name of M. le Prince was being announced. The Prince de Condé, the first prince of the blood, the conqueror of Rocroi, Lens, and Nordlingen, was, in fact, entering the apartment of Monseigneur de Mazarin, followed by his gentlemen, and had already saluted the king, when the prime minister raised his curtain. Athos had time to see Raoul pressing the hand of the Comte de Guiche, and send him a smile in return for his respectful bow. He had time, likewise, to see the radiant countenance of the cardinal, when he perceived before him, upon the table, an enormous heap of gold, which the Comte de Guiche had won in a run of luck, after his eminence had confided his cards to him. So forgetting ambassador, embassy and prince, his first thought was of the gold. ‘What!’ cried the old man—‘all that—won?’

‘Some fifty thousand crowns; yes, monseigneur,’ replied the Comte de Guiche, rising. ‘Must I give up my place to your eminence, or shall I continue?’

‘Give up! give up! you are mad. You would lose all you have won. Peste!’

‘My lord!’ said the Prince de Condé, bowing.

‘Good-evening, monsieur le prince,’ said the minister, in a careless tone; ‘it is very kind of you to visit an old sick friend.’

‘Yes, my lord.’

His eminence sank down for a moment, like an unfortunate wretch who is crushed by a falling column. But the spirit of Mazarin was a strong one, or rather his mind was a firm one. ‘Guenaud,’ said he, recovering from his first shock, ‘you will permit me to appeal from your judgment. I will call together the most learned men of Europe: I will consult them. I will live, in short, by the virtue of I care not what remedy.’

‘My lord must not suppose,’ said Guenaud, ‘that I have the presumption to pronounce alone upon an existence so valuable as yours. I have already assembled all the good physicians and practitioners of France and Europe. There were twelve of them.’

‘And they said—’

‘They said that your eminence was suffering from a mortal disease; I have the consultation signed in my portfolio. If your eminence will please to see it, you will find the names of all the incurable diseases we have met with. There is first—’

‘No, no!’ cried Mazarin, pushing away the paper. ‘No, no, Guenaud, I yield! I yield!’ And a profound silence, during which the cardinal resumed his senses and recovered his strength, succeeded to the agitation of this scene. ‘There is another thing,’ murmured Mazarin; ‘there are empirics and charlatans. In my country, those whom physicians abandon run the chance of a quack, who kills them ten times but saves them a hundred times.’

‘Has not your eminence observed, that during the last month I have changed my remedies ten times?’

‘Yes. Well?’

‘Well, I have spent fifty thousand crowns in purchasing the secrets of all these fellows: the list is exhausted, and so is my purse. You are not cured! and, but for my art, you would be dead.’

‘That ends it!’ murmured the cardinal; ‘that ends it.’ And he threw a melancholy look upon the riches which surrounded him. ‘And must I quit all that?’ sighed he. ‘I am dying, Guenaud! I am dying!’

‘Oh! not yet, my lord,’ said the physician.

Mazarin seized his hand. ‘In what time?’ asked he, fixing his two large eyes upon the impassible countenance of the physician.

‘My lord, we never tell that.’

‘To ordinary men, perhaps not—but to me—to me, whose every minute is worth a treasure. Tell me, Guenaud, tell me!’

‘No, no, my lord.’

‘I insist upon it, I tell you. Oh! give me a month, and for every one of those thirty days I will pay you a hundred thousand crowns.’

‘My lord,’ replied Guenaud, in a firm voice, ‘it is God who can give you days of grace, and not I. God only allows you a fortnight.’

The cardinal breathed a painful sigh, and sank back down upon his pillow, murmuring, ‘Thank you, Guenaud, thank you!’

The physician was about to depart, the dying man, raising himself up: ‘Silence!’ said he, with flaming eyes, ‘silence!’

‘My lord, I have known this secret two months; you see that I have kept it faithfully.’

‘Go, Guenaud; I will take care of your fortunes; go, and tell Brienne to send me a clerk called M. Colbert. Go!’

hand; I am therefore ignorant of how he treated with prime ministers. As for the king of England, Charles II., I know that when he writes to his majesty King Louis XIV, he does not write to his eminence the Cardinal Mazarin. I see no diplomacy in that distinction.’

‘Ah!’ cried Mazarin, raising his attenuated hand, and striking his head, ‘I remember now?’ Athos looked at him in astonishment. ‘Yes, that is it!’ said the cardinal, continuing to look at his interlocutor; ‘yes, that is certainly it. I know you now, monsieur. Ah! diavolo! I am no longer astonished.’

‘In fact, I was astonished that, with your eminence’s excellent memory,’ replied Athos, smiling, ‘you had not recognized me before.’

‘Always refractory and grumbling—monsieur—monsieur—What do they call you? Stop—a name of a river—Potamos; no—the name of an island—Naxos; no, per Giove!—the name of a mountain—Athos! now I have it. Delighted to see you again, and to be no longer at Ruell, where you and your damned companions made me pay ransom. Fronde! still Fronde! accursed Fronde! Oh, what grudges! Why, monsieur, have your antipathies survived mine? If any one has cause to complain, I think it could not be you, who got out of the affair not only in a sound skin, but with the cordon of the Holy Ghost around your neck.’

‘My lord cardinal,’ replied Athos, ‘permit me not to enter into considerations of that kind. I have a mission to fulfill. Will you facilitate the means of my fulfilling that mission, or will you not?’

‘I am astonished,’ said Mazarin,—quite delighted at having recovered his memory, and bristling with malice,—‘I am astonished, Monsieur—Athos—that a Frondeur like you should have accepted a mission for the Perfidious Mazarin, as used to be said in the good old times—’ And Mazarin began to laugh, in spite of a painful cough, which cut short his sentences, converting them into sobs.

‘I have only accepted the mission near the king of France, monsieur le cardinal,’ retorted the comte, though with less asperity, for he thought he had sufficiently the advantage to show himself moderate.

‘And yet, Monsieur le Frondeur,’ said Mazarin, gayly, ‘the affair which you have taken in charge must, from the king—’

‘With which I have been given in charge, monseigneur. I do not run after affairs.’